



# Acqlerate

## The Acquisition Starter Kit

Your essential field guide to navigating the DoD acquisition landscape — from pathways and milestones to common pitfalls and pro strategies. Built for early-career program managers, acquisition professionals, and government contractors who need practical, actionable guidance from day one.

# Section 1: DoD Acquisition Lifecycle Cheat Sheet

The Adaptive Acquisition Framework (AAF), codified in DoDI 5000.02, replaced the legacy "one-size-fits-all" acquisition model with six tailored pathways. Each pathway is designed to match the unique characteristics of different program types — from urgent battlefield needs to large-scale major capability investments. Understanding which pathway applies to your program is the foundational first step for any acquisition professional. The right pathway determines your documentation requirements, milestone structure, oversight level, and the decision authority who approves your program. Choosing incorrectly — or failing to advocate for the right pathway — can add years of unnecessary delay and bureaucratic overhead to a program that could have moved faster under a more appropriate framework.



## Urgent Capability Acquisition (UCA)

Delivers capabilities within **2 years** to address urgent operational needs. Governed by DoDI 5000.81. Bypasses traditional milestone reviews. Used for warfighter-identified urgent needs validated by combatant commanders.



## Middle Tier of Acquisition (MTA)

Two sub-paths: **Rapid Prototyping** (5 years to fielding) and **Rapid Fielding** (6 years, mature tech). Governed by DoDI 5000.80. Streamlined for speed, with no MDAPs designation required.



## Major Capability Acquisition (MCA)

The traditional milestone-driven pathway: **Milestones A, B, and C** with full JCIDS requirements. Governed by DoDI 5000.85. Used for complex, high-cost platforms. Requires DAE or CAE approval at key decision points.



## Software Acquisition

Governed by DoDI 5000.87. Embraces **Agile and DevSecOps** delivery cycles. Software capability drops every 6 months. No traditional milestone structure — uses Capability Needs Statement instead of CDD.



## Defense Business Systems (DBS)

Governed by DoDI 5000.75. For IT and business systems supporting financial, HR, and logistics functions. Requires **Business Capability Acquisition Cycle (BCAC)** approval. Investment Review Board oversight mandatory.



## Acquisition of Services

Governed by DoDI 5000.74. Applies to **services contracts** exceeding \$250M. Requires a Services Acquisition Strategy and portfolio management review. Distinct from product acquisition — PWSs and PBAs are central documents.



For the MCA pathway specifically, milestone reviews are the gating mechanism through which programs must pass before advancing to the next phase. Missing a milestone — or failing to properly document the required artifacts — can halt a program entirely. Understanding what evidence and documentation each milestone demands is critical knowledge for any program manager operating in the MCA environment.



## Section 2: Key Acronym Glossary

The DoD acquisition ecosystem runs on acronyms. Fluency in this language is a professional necessity — not optional background knowledge. Whether you're reviewing a program's acquisition strategy, sitting in a CDR, or preparing a PEO briefing, you will encounter these terms constantly. This reference covers the 50+ most critical acronyms across the acquisition lifecycle, from requirements generation through contract execution and oversight. Bookmark this section; it will save you from the embarrassing pause of asking "what does that mean again?" in front of senior leadership.

| Acronym   | Definition                                |
|-----------|-------------------------------------------|
| AAF       | Adaptive Acquisition Framework            |
| ACAT      | Acquisition Category                      |
| ACO       | Administrative Contracting Officer        |
| ADM       | Acquisition Decision Memorandum           |
| AoA       | Analysis of Alternatives                  |
| APB       | Acquisition Program Baseline              |
| ASA(AL&T) | Asst. Secretary of Army (Acq, Log & Tech) |
| ASARC     | Army Systems Acquisition Review Council   |
| AT&L      | Acquisition, Technology, and Logistics    |
| BCL       | Budget Change Letter                      |
| CAE       | Component Acquisition Executive           |
| CBA       | Capabilities-Based Assessment             |
| CCP       | Contract Change Proposal                  |
| CDD       | Capability Development Document           |
| CDR       | Critical Design Review                    |
| CDRL      | Contract Data Requirements List           |
| CLIN      | Contract Line Item Number                 |
| CPD       | Capability Production Document            |
| CPIF      | Cost Plus Incentive Fee                   |
| CUI       | Controlled Unclassified Information       |
| DAE       | Defense Acquisition Executive             |
| DAES      | Defense Acquisition Executive Summary     |
| DAU       | Defense Acquisition University            |
| DAWIA     | Defense Acq. Workforce Improvement Act    |
| DBS       | Defense Business Systems                  |

| Acronym      | Definition                                                               |
|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| DDR&E        | Director, Defense Research & Engineering                                 |
| DoDI         | DoD Instruction                                                          |
| DOTMLPF      | Doctrine, Organization, Training, Mat, Leadership, Personnel, Facilities |
| EMD          | Engineering and Manufacturing Development                                |
| EVM          | Earned Value Management                                                  |
| EVMS         | Earned Value Management System                                           |
| FAR          | Federal Acquisition Regulation                                           |
| FPIF         | Fixed Price Incentive Firm                                               |
| FYDP         | Future Years Defense Program                                             |
| ICE          | Independent Cost Estimate                                                |
| ICD          | Initial Capabilities Document                                            |
| IMP          | Integrated Master Plan                                                   |
| IMS          | Integrated Master Schedule                                               |
| IPT          | Integrated Product Team                                                  |
| JCIDS        | Joint Capabilities Integration & Dev. System                             |
| JROC         | Joint Requirements Oversight Council                                     |
| KPP          | Key Performance Parameter                                                |
| KSA          | Key System Attribute                                                     |
| LRIP         | Low-Rate Initial Production                                              |
| MCA          | Major Capability Acquisition                                             |
| MDA          | Milestone Decision Authority                                             |
| MDAP         | Major Defense Acquisition Program                                        |
| MTA          | Middle Tier of Acquisition                                               |
| Nunn-McCurdy | Statutory cost breach notification law                                   |
| O&S          | Operations and Support                                                   |
| OSD          | Office of the Secretary of Defense                                       |
| PDR          | Preliminary Design Review                                                |
| PEO          | Program Executive Officer                                                |
| PM           | Program Manager                                                          |
| PWS          | Performance Work Statement                                               |
| RFP          | Request for Proposal                                                     |
| SOW          | Statement of Work                                                        |
| SRR          | System Requirements Review                                               |
| TRL          | Technology Readiness Level                                               |
| UCA          | Urgent Capability Acquisition                                            |



**Pro Tip:** When you encounter an unfamiliar acronym in a contract, directive, or briefing, the first step is always to look it up in the source document's list of abbreviations — then cross-reference with the relevant DoDI. Never assume you know what an acronym means based on similar civilian terminology. In DoD acquisition, "PM" means Program Manager — not Project Manager — and the distinction matters significantly in terms of authority and responsibility.

## Section 3: ACAT Decision Tree

The Acquisition Category (ACAT) system determines the level of oversight, review authority, and documentation burden your program carries. It is not merely administrative labeling — your ACAT level determines who approves your milestones, how often you report to OSD, and what statutory requirements apply. Programs are categorized based on estimated total acquisition cost thresholds, research and development investment, and the complexity and strategic sensitivity of the capability. ACAT I programs receive the most oversight and report to the Defense Acquisition Executive or a Service Acquisition Executive. ACAT II and III programs have progressively lighter oversight. Understanding where your program sits — and knowing the thresholds that could elevate it — is essential knowledge for any PM.

### ACAT I: Maximum Oversight

- RDT&E > \$480M, or Procurement > \$2.79B
- DAE or SAE is Milestone Decision Authority
- Mandatory DAES reporting to OSD
- Full JCIDS documentation required (ICD, CDD, CPD)
- Congressional notification required at milestones
- Nunn-McCurdy applies at 15% and 25% cost breaches

### ACAT II: Component Oversight

- RDT&E \$185M–\$480M, or Procurement \$720M–\$2.79B
- Component Acquisition Executive (CAE) is MDA
- Reporting at component level — not OSD
- Streamlined documentation requirements
- CDD still required; CPD at Milestone C
- Greater flexibility in acquisition strategy

### ACAT III: Program Office Oversight

- Below ACAT II thresholds
- PEO or designated official is MDA
- Maximum flexibility in documentation and process
- Component-level reporting only
- Can still use MCA, MTA, or other pathways
- Ideal for rapid, lower-cost capability fielding

📌 **Watch for ACAT Breaches:** Programs can be re-categorized upward if costs grow. A Nunn-McCurdy breach at 15% triggers a notification to Congress; at 25% (a "significant" breach), the program must be certified by the Under Secretary of Defense or face termination. Track your APB thresholds relentlessly.

## Section 4: 5 Most Common Mistakes New PMs Make

The transition into a program manager role is one of the steepest learning curves in government service. The technical knowledge, regulatory familiarity, and stakeholder management skills required are immense — and there is rarely enough time to develop them through formal training alone before the first milestone review arrives. The five mistakes below are drawn from patterns observed across dozens of programs and program offices. Recognizing them early — ideally before you make them yourself — can save your program months of recovery time and protect your professional reputation with PEO leadership and oversight bodies.



# Mistake #1–3: Schedule, Nunn-McCurdy & EVM

## ✗ Mistake #1: Treating the IMS as a Reporting Tool, Not a Management Tool

The IMS should be your primary tool for tracking program health — every work package, every dependency, every critical path relationship must reflect reality. A schedule that shows green when the program is actually amber or red doesn't protect you; it exposes you to far greater risk when the truth surfaces at a major milestone review. Best practice: hold weekly schedule scrubs with your IPT leads, enforce schedule discipline at the work package level, and never let the IMS drift more than one reporting cycle from ground truth.

## ✗ Mistake #2: Not Knowing Your Nunn-McCurdy Thresholds

Many new PMs know Nunn-McCurdy exists but have never calculated their program's specific breach thresholds in dollar terms. This is dangerous. You should know, at any given moment, exactly how much cost growth — in total dollars and as a percentage — separates your program from each threshold. Brief your PEO on this quarterly. Never let a potential breach be a surprise to your chain of command.

## ✗ Mistake #3: Misunderstanding Earned Value Management Signals

EVM is the most powerful program health diagnostic tool available to PMs — and one of the most misunderstood. New PMs often focus on SPI (Schedule Performance Index) and CPI (Cost Performance Index) as standalone numbers without understanding the trend direction or the "to-complete" indices. A CPI of 0.92 may be acceptable if it has been trending upward for three months; the same CPI trending downward signals a fundamentally failing program. Equally important: EVM only reflects what has been authorized, budgeted, and reported by the contractor. If your EVMS surveillance is weak or your contractor's system is not DCMA-accepted, your EVM data may be telling you a story that bears no resemblance to actual program performance.

# Mistake #4–5: Requirements & Stakeholder Management



## ✗ Mistake #4: Writing Vague or Untestable Requirements

Requirements are the contractual and technical foundation of your entire program. Vague requirements — those that cannot be tested, measured, or verified — create one of the most expensive failure modes in defense acquisition: requirements creep and contract disputes. New PMs often inherit CDDs and CPDs with KPPs written at a high level of abstraction, then fail to ensure those requirements are properly traced and tightened in the system specification and the contract's Statement of Work. The result is a contractor who builds to the minimum interpretation of the requirement, and a government customer who expected something more capable. Every KPP in your CDD should have a corresponding verification method, an acceptance threshold, and an objective value. If your requirements team cannot write a test procedure for a requirement, that requirement needs to be rewritten before it enters the contract.



## ✗ Mistake #5: Underinvesting in Stakeholder Management

Program managers who focus exclusively on technical and contractual execution — while neglecting the human terrain of their stakeholder network — consistently struggle at milestone reviews and budget hearings. Your stakeholders include your PEO, the operational user community, the requirements community (JROC-level for ACAT I), OSD Cost Assessment and Program Evaluation (CAPE), the Comptroller, congressional staffers, and your prime contractor's leadership. Each has different equities, different information needs, and different definitions of program success. New PMs often wait until a problem is visible before engaging upward — this is a mistake. Proactive, consistent, honest communication with your stakeholder network builds the political capital you will desperately need when your first real program challenge arrives. Build your stakeholder communication plan on Day 1 and treat it as seriously as your Integrated Master Schedule.

72%

Programs Over  
Budget

of ACAT I programs exceed their original cost baseline at Milestone C

4.2yr

Avg Schedule Slip

average schedule growth on major defense acquisition programs from MS B to IOC

\$500B+

In Cost Overruns

cumulative cost growth across the DoD MDAP portfolio in recent years

Day 1

Start Planning

the right day to build your stakeholder management plan and schedule baseline

# Ready to Go Deeper? **Acqlerate** Has You Covered.

The Acquisition Starter Kit is just the beginning. Acqlerate — the Defense Acquisitions Academy — has built six comprehensive learning modules specifically designed to take acquisition professionals from foundational knowledge to operational mastery. Whether you are preparing for your first milestone review, navigating a complex contract negotiation, or building the program management skills to advance your career, Acqlerate's curriculum delivers the practical, scenario-based learning that traditional training programs miss. Every module is built around real-world acquisition challenges, not abstract theory.



## Module 1: AAF Pathways Mastery

Deep dive into all six AAF pathways with case studies and decision frameworks to choose the right path for any program.



## Module 2: Cost, Schedule & EVM

Master Earned Value Management, schedule risk analysis, and cost estimating fundamentals that PMs use every day.



## Module 3: Requirements & JCIDS

Write testable, traceable requirements and navigate the JCIDS process from ICD through CPD with confidence.



## Module 4: Contracting Fundamentals

Understand contract types, FAR/DFARS compliance, source selection, and how to partner effectively with your PCO.



## Module 5: Stakeholder & Risk Management

Build stakeholder maps, communication plans, and risk registers that protect your program from the most common failure modes.



## Module 6: PM Career Accelerator

Prepare for DAWIA certification, develop your leadership brand, and position yourself for Program Manager selection boards.

"The best program managers don't just know the regulations — they understand the system well enough to move fast, build trust, and deliver capability. That's what Acqlerate is built to teach."

[Start Learning at Acqlerate](#)

[View All 6 Modules](#)



# Quick Reference: AAF Pathway Selector

Not sure which pathway applies to your program? Use this quick-reference guide to identify the most likely fit based on your program's characteristics. Remember: the Milestone Decision Authority makes the final pathway determination, but a well-prepared PM should enter that conversation with a clear, data-supported recommendation. Selecting the right pathway early prevents costly re-baselining later and ensures your program office is staffed, resourced, and structured for the right oversight model from the start.

| Pathway                  | Best For                                         | Key Timeline                 | Governing DoDI | MDA Level                  |
|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|------------------------------|----------------|----------------------------|
| Urgent Capability (UCA)  | Urgent warfighter needs, validated by CCDR       | ≤ 2 years to fielding        | DoDI 5000.81   | CAE or designated official |
| Middle Tier (MTA)        | Rapid prototype or rapid fielding of mature tech | 5–6 years max                | DoDI 5000.80   | CAE                        |
| Major Capability (MCA)   | Complex, high-cost systems; full lifecycle       | Milestone-driven (A, B, C)   | DoDI 5000.85   | DAE or SAE                 |
| Software Acquisition     | Software-intensive programs; Agile delivery      | 6-month capability drops     | DoDI 5000.87   | CAE                        |
| Defense Business Systems | Enterprise IT; financial/HR/logistics systems    | BCAC review cycle            | DoDI 5000.75   | IRB + CAE                  |
| Acquisition of Services  | Services contracts > \$250M                      | Services Acq. Strategy cycle | DoDI 5000.74   | SAE or designated          |

 **Remember:** Pathways are not mutually exclusive in all cases. A program may use the MTA Rapid Prototyping pathway to mature a technology, then transition into MCA for full-rate production. Document your pathway transition rationale clearly in your Acquisition Strategy.

# Your Next Step Starts Now

You now have in your hands the core reference material that most acquisition professionals spend months assembling on their own — the AAF pathway breakdown, the critical acronym glossary, the ACAT decision framework, and the five hard-won lessons from programs that learned the expensive way. This is your foundation. But a foundation is only as valuable as what you build on top of it.

Acqlerate was built by acquisition professionals who have lived these challenges across ACAT I programs, rapid acquisition efforts, and everything in between. The six learning modules available at **acqlerate.com** will take you from this starter kit level to the kind of deep, operational fluency that gets PMs selected for executive positions, trusted with the most complex programs, and recognized as the professional who actually knows what they are doing when it matters most.

## Step 1

Bookmark this starter kit and share it with your IPT and program office colleagues who could benefit.

## Step 2

Visit **acqlerate.com** and enroll in Module 1: AAF Pathways Mastery — the logical next step from this guide.

## Step 3

Complete all six modules and earn your Acqlerate certification to validate your acquisition expertise.

The DoD needs acquisition professionals who are ready on Day 1. **Acqlerate.com** — the Defense Acquisitions Academy.

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